

HL Vocabulary

The widget above **is** the table — it's an interactive, filterable table with columns for Term, Category, Definition, Tools, Why managers care, and Critical view. You can search and filter by category.

If it's not rendering properly on your end, here it is as a plain markdown table:

Term	Category	Definition	Tools	Why managers care	Critical view
Status Quo	Culture	The current state of things — how work is being done right now. Often referenced when someone wants to challenge or preserve existing practices.	Retros, OKR planning, roadmap discussions	Leaders use it to frame change management: are we challenging it or protecting it?	Often weaponised to resist change or overstate urgency. Ask what evidence supports changing it.

PR (Pull Request)	Process	A developer's formal request to merge their code branch into the main codebase. Triggers review, discussion, and automated checks.	GitHub, GitLab, Bitbucket — linked from Jira	Managers track PR throughput and age to spot bottlenecks.	Large, long-lived PRs become review nightmares. If PRs sit open for days, it signals poor async culture or overloaded reviewers.
Peer Review	Quality	Having another engineer review your work before it's merged or shipped. Catches bugs, shares knowledge, enforces standards.	GitHub PR reviews, Confluence, Figma comments	Reduces defect rate, spreads ownership, prevents knowledge silos.	Can become a rubber-stamp if culture doesn't reward thorough feedback. Reviewers under pressure approve things they haven't truly read.

Unit Test	Quality	An automated test that checks a single, isolated piece of code works as expected. Part of the broader testing pyramid.	Jest, JUnit, PyTest — results in CI/CD pipelines	High coverage gives confidence to refactor and ship faster. Low coverage signals technical debt.	Coverage % is a vanity metric — 90% coverage can still mean a broken product if tests don't test meaningful behaviour.
Cycle Time	Metrics	Elapsed time from when a developer starts a ticket to when it's deployed to production. One of the four DORA metrics.	Jira cycle time reports, LinearB, Jellyfish, Swarmia	Lower cycle time = faster feedback loops. Managers track it to find where work gets stuck.	Optimising cycle time alone can encourage rushed work and skipped reviews. Read it alongside change failure rate.

Evangelis e	Culture	To actively promote a technology, practice, or idea internally or externally. Common for platform teams and architecture leads.	Confluence, Slack, tech talks, blog posts	Adoption of new tools rarely happens without internal champions. Leaders look for people who can persuade without authority.	Evangelism without listening becomes preaching. The best advocates shape the thing they're promoting, not just sell it.
Metrics for Releases	Metrics	Quantitative measures for release health — deployment frequency, change failure rate, MTTR.	Jira, Datadog, PagerDuty, Grafana	Replaces gut-feel with trend lines for resourcing and process decisions.	Teams can game metrics (e.g. splitting tickets to boost deploy frequency). Metrics always need context.

E-commerce	Product	Buying and selling online. In tech interviews, means the domain your product lives in: checkout, catalogues, payments, inventory.	Shopify, Stripe, Salesforce Commerce	Signals business model and stakes — e-commerce bugs directly cost revenue.	Used very loosely. Always clarify scope — it can mean a 3-person startup or a 50-team platform org.
ALC	Process	Architecture and Leadership Council — a governance body that reviews significant technical decisions before they're committed to.	Confluence (ADRs/RFCs), formal review meetings	Prevents costly rework by catching bad architectural decisions early.	Can become a bureaucratic gatekeeper that slows teams without adding value. The best ones give fast, async decisions.

Jira	Tool	Atlassian's project tracking tool. Used to create, assign, prioritise, and track tasks through a workflow.	GitHub, Confluence, Slack integrations	Provides visibility across teams. Managers track sprint progress, blocked tickets, and velocity.	Jira-heavy cultures optimise for ticket-closing over outcomes. Backlog grooming can consume time needed for actual work.
Confluence	Tool	Atlassian's wiki and documentation platform. Used for specs, post-mortems, architecture decisions, onboarding guides.	Links from Jira, used alongside Notion, Google Docs	Institutional knowledge lives here. Leaders check if teams document decisions or keep things in people's heads.	Often becomes a graveyard of outdated pages. Stale docs create false confidence — people make decisions based on wrong information.

OKRs	Product	Objectives and Key Results — a goal-setting framework. Objective = qualitative ambition; Key Results = measurable outcomes.	Confluence, Notion, Lattice, Weekdone	Aligns teams to company strategy. Every roadmap decision should trace back to an OKR.	Can become a checkbox exercise. If set top-down without team input or never reviewed, they're shelfware with branding.
DORA Metrics	Metrics	Four research-backed metrics: Deployment Frequency, Lead Time for Changes, Change Failure Rate, and MTTR.	LinearB, Jellyfish, Faros, Grafana	Gold standard for engineering health. VPs use them to benchmark teams and justify process investments.	Designed for elite DevOps teams. Applying them rigidly to early-stage startups can misrepresent performance.

Sprint / Iteration	Process	A fixed-length work cycle (1–2 weeks) in Agile/ Scrum. Team commits to tasks, then reviews what shipped at the end.	Jira Sprints, Linear Cycles, Shortcut	Creates a rhythm for planning and feedback. Managers track velocity to forecast roadmap delivery.	Can create artificial urgency and context-switching. Some teams do better with Kanban (continuous flow).
Technical Debt	Process	The implied cost of shortcuts taken in code — quick fixes or outdated designs that need to be addressed later.	Jira, SonarQube, Confluence (debt registers)	Unmanaged debt slows future development. Leaders want to see a plan for it.	The "debt" metaphor implies it's always intentional. Often it accumulates from poor decisions, not strategic trade-offs.
Retrospective	Collab	A recurring meeting to reflect on what went well, what didn't, and what to change. Core Agile ceremony.	Miro, EasyRetro, Confluence, Jira (action items)	Continuous improvement signal. Leaders look for retros that produce real changes, not just vent sessions.	Becomes performative in psychologically unsafe teams. People raise safe topics instead of real problems.

SLA / SLO / SLI	Metrics	SLA = customer-facing commitment. SLO = internal target (e.g. 99.9% uptime). SLI = the actual measurement.	Datadog, PagerDuty , Prometheus, Grafana	Defines what "good" looks like for reliability. Used to decide when to invest in reliability vs features.	SLAs often set without engineering input, creating politically driven targets teams then sandbag or constantly breach.
Roadmap	Product	A prioritised plan of what a team will build and when — usually covering the next quarter to year.	Jira Advanced Roadmaps , Productboard, Notion	Communicates priorities to stakeholders. Engineers should understand and challenge items that don't make technical sense.	Creates a false promise of certainty. Stakeholders treat them as contracts; teams treat them as aspirations.

Incident / Post-mortem	Process	An incident is an unexpected failure. A post-mortem is the blameless analysis written after — timeline, root cause, prevention.	PagerDuty , Opsgenie, Confluence, Jira	Shows team maturity. Leaders look for blameless post-mortems and whether action items get closed.	Blameless culture is aspirational in many orgs. Post-mortems can become political documents protecting individuals.
Bus Factor	Collab	The number of people who'd need to leave for a project to be in serious trouble. Low bus factor = fragile team.	Confluence, pair programming, GitHub CODEOWNERS	Exposes knowledge concentration risk. Leaders actively work to raise this number across critical systems.	Efforts to raise it are often deprioritized under delivery pressure — until someone leaves and the risk becomes real.